

Caulk, Joints and Where Water Gets In

Your most-missed question on this topic is about caulk, and the trap is that the right answer calls it temporary.

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 5 TIMES

**Gaps around doors and windows in exterior siding need to be caulked:
As a temporary repair.**

Five times missed. Caulk around an opening in siding is a stopgap: it is filling a gap that exists because the flashing or the trim detail behind it is not doing its job. It will shrink, crack and need doing again. Calling it temporary is the honest inspection language, and the exam wants that word.

Caulk is temporary here, and correct at the driveway joint

In Site Conditions, caulking the seam where a driveway or walk meets the foundation is the recommended answer, because that joint is designed to move and a flexible sealant is the right tool for a moving joint. Around siding openings it is a temporary repair standing in for proper flashing. Same material, two different verdicts — the question is whether caulk is the intended detail or a substitute for one.

Where a house does get caulked

Asked as a list — around windows, around doors, at trim joints, where dissimilar materials meet — the answer is all of them. This is one of the genuinely cumulative questions: the options are separate locations, not competing candidates, so "all of the answers" is live.

Trim, and one place water is not the point

Cornice	The trim piece at the top of a wall where it meets the roof overhang.
Batten	A narrow strip of wood, plastic, metal or gypsum used to conceal an open joint — as in board-and-batten siding.
Exterior grade gypsum board	Suitable for a protected soffit-type location: the ceiling in a carport is the example the exam uses.

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS

**Which is most likely to be a problem when an emitter is located near the house?
Water will enter the crawl space or basement.**

An irrigation emitter beside the wall puts water into the ground next to the foundation on a timer. It is the same failure as a downspout discharging at the wall, just deliberate — and the consequence is water inside, not damaged siding.

Say it back

Cover the page. Answer each one out loud.

1. Gaps around doors and windows in siding are caulked as what?
2. Why is caulk temporary here but recommended at a driveway-to-foundation joint?
3. Where should a house be caulked?
4. What is a cornice, and what is a batten?
5. Where does exterior grade gypsum board belong?
6. An irrigation emitter sits near the house. What is the likely problem?